# Guide to Belly (Diaphragmatic) Breathing

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Belly breathing or diaphragmatic breathing is:

- Gently filling & emptying the lungs like balloons which helps us feel more relaxed and centered using a relaxation response.
- The important thing is to feel the rise and fall of the belly. (your chest may expand a bit but ideally stays pretty still).
- It is the opposite of chest or shallow breathing. (Chest/shallow breathing is usually what we do when stressed or fearful).

## The Steps of Belly Breathing:

- Sit or lie down with a straight spine and all limbs uncrossed.
- Place one hand on your belly and one hand on your chest
- Breathe in slowly through the nose. Inflate the lungs gently like balloons. Feel the belly rise or move outward.
- Exhale slowly through pursed lips or nose. Feel the belly deflate inward.
- Take even breaths. Count about 4 beats inhaling & 4 beats exhaling.
- It may feel awkward at first & take some practice to get the hang of it.
- It's often recommended to start doing 10-20 breaths several times a day.
    - When you breathe IN the belly expands OUT
    - When you breathe OUT the belly deflates IN

Why Belly (Diaphragmatic) Breathing is important:

- Diaphragmatic breaths send messages of relaxation to the brain via a mind-body feedback loop,
- It brings lots of fresh oxygen into the body.
- Tension and stress can be reduced

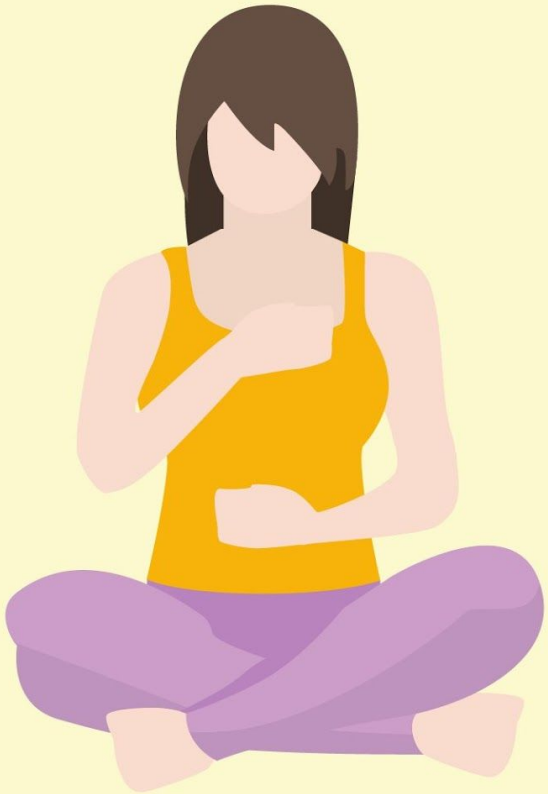
-This is meant as a guide and is not medical advice. If you feel badly in any way as you practice it, stop and come back to it at a later time.

# Pinwheel Belly Breathing for Kids

Kids can learn to belly breathe with the a **pinwheel** by inhaling through the nose as if they're smelling a flower and then exhaling

## BREATHE IN, BELLY OUT

- Place one hand on your chest and the other on your belly.
- Inhale deeply through your nose for a count of four, making sure your belly abdomen is expanding and not your chest. Exhale for a count of four.
- Continue this breathing cycle for a few minutes.
- Feel the stress leave your body while your mind becomes calm.



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